

THE EX-HUSBAND

Hazel and Wukong. While the rest of the Party heads off to talk to Breakbones and Angwyn, both of you head back to your assigned rooms in the inner bailey, having deposited your bags there earlier in the day upon your arrival.

“Actually, we should check up on Thaisha,” Hazel replies. “I haven’t seen her since we entered the Camp.” The pair head into Thaisha’s room, hoping to see if she has headed off to anywhere.

WISDOM (SURVIVAL) CHECK

On a successful DC 20 check, Hazel finds Thaisha’s room filled with her unpacked luggage. She sniffs the air and follows tracks left by Thaisha, who seemed to have rushed off almost immediately after setting her stuff down.

Following her trail, Hazel and Wukong heads off to the southern side of the camp, finding two well-appointed wooden houses. They spy a shrine decorated with teal banners and candles, which Hazel recognizes as a shrine dedicated to the Candescent Church.

In the other house, the pair hears soft moans of pleasure. Peeking his head in, Wukong sees two half-orcs having deep, passionate doggy-style sex.



“Oh shit!” Thaisha notices the paladin spying on her. The half-orc druid squirms away from the half-orc man, embarrassed, and begins getting dressed. “Wait a minute! W- What the hells are you guys doing here?”

Stumbling out into the courtyard, barely dressed is a flustered Thaisha and a handsome half-orc. The man comes out with a charming smile, and offers his hand out to Wukong. “Hi, I’m Halandil,” he says. “And you must be Wukong, and Hazel. Pleasure to meet you, Thaisha has told me so much about you.”

Looking in, Hazel spots Fiverr’s belongings. She intuits that this is where the 74th Expedition are sleeping.

“Okay, um, sorry you all had to see that,” Thaisha explains. “This is Hal, my ex-husband.”

“Pleasure to meet you all, really,” Halandil continues. “Now, I hope to see all of you at the dinner tonight, you know.”

“Oh, you’re going too?” Wukong asks.

“Yes, yes,” Halandil replies. “Very kind of the Senator. She has invited the 74th Expedition, as well, us being all here on official business.”

“And what is your profession?” Hazel asks.

The half-orc gives a half bow. “I am a humble bard,” Halandil says. “Proprietor of the Hallowed Round.”

“Nice to meet you,” Hazel says. “But we really should be going.”

“Yes, of course,” Thaisha steals a last long look at Halandil, as if to decide if she should stay with him or to go with the Party.

“You coming, Thaisha?” Hazel asks.

“Yes, let’s go,” the druid says. The trio leaves, heading back to their rooms in the inner bailey. As she heads out of earshot from Halandil, Thaisha quickly whispers, “And if you both don’t mind, please, please keep this a secret from the rest of the group? I’m really embarrassed - “

“It’s okay,” Hazel assures. “We’ll keep it quiet.”

THE CELESTIAL SOLDIER

As you all return to your rooms to freshen up, Wukong you see a man with a dark, slate grey tunic with gold trimmed armour with his back towards you. He seems to be rifling through your stuff, checking out whatever items lay on your desk.

“Who are you?” The paladin demands.

“Good morning, soldier,” Erlangshen replies in Celestial. “Ready to comply?”

You feel a tremendous amount of pain as your *Headband of Intellect* tightens around your head. You stumble backwards as your vision grows black.

Wukong grunts in pain, drawing Hazel’s attention. The harregon shuts her eyes and activates her tremorsense, picking up two bodies in Wukong’s room. The cleric fishes out her Sending stone and calls everyone to rally at Wukong’s room, afraid that something has gone awry.

As suddenly as it began, Wukong you awaken. The vice-like grip of the headband around your head leaves a dull ache, and you see outside now that a considerable amount of time has passed. Staring at you just beyond the threshold of the door, is everybody in your Party - Hazel, Wang Lei, Salazar, Raphael and Vilde.

You notice that set on the table is a small, colorful ring with a hummingbird. You recognize this as a *Ring of Evasion*.

“Uh, is everything alright?” Hazel asks. The cleric leaps up and examines the simian.

WISDOM (MEDICINE) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel sees that the paladin is not cursed or under any magical influence. It appears that Wukong is in full control of his faculties.

“Erlangshen was here,” Wukong says. “Somebody who has been pursuing me.”

“Are you sure?” Salazar asks. “It’s a hot day, are you sure you weren’t just hallucinating?”

INTELLIGENCE (ARCANA) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Wukong checks himself and finds no tracking sigils or brands of any kinds.

Wukong picks up the *Ring of Evasion* and examines it. “I don’t think so,” he continues. “It felt very real. And, I don’t know. I’ve never had this ring before, and now I do. He must have physically been here.”

“Okay, this kind of thing happens all the time,” Hazel says. “I’ve gotta go back and do my make-up, so if there’s nothing else...”

The Party splinters off to head back to their room to prepare for their dinner with the Senator.



A DINNER TO DIE FOR

Having made plans to run off once again, Vilde pens a quick letter to explain. She writes, “It’s me again. Sorry Mummy and Daddy - I’ve thought about it, and I have to find my own place in the world. I recently met a bard, and the lyrics of the song really resonated with me. I appreciate your care and concern, but I gotta go my own way. Love you, Vilde, your forever daughter.”

GOTTA GO MY OWN WAY

I gotta say what’s on my mind

Something about us doesn’t seem right these days

Life keeps getting in the way

Whenever we try, somehow the plan

Is always rearranged

It’s so hard to say

But I’ve gotta do what’s best for me

You’ll be okay

I’ve got to move on and be who I am

I just don’t belong here, I hope you understand

We might find a place in this world someday

But at least for now

I gotta go my own way (own way)

CHARISMA (PERSUASION) CHECK

Signed with love and strengthened by the power of the ballad, someone reading the letter will need to beat a DC 20 check to not be swayed by its contents.

Vilde pockets the letter, intending to give it to her Daddy later.

As the sun wends its way towards the horizon, all of you head back from your various conversations to prepare for dinner. As it is customary with eating with a noble, all of you go to shower and shed your arms and armour. Once done, all of you make your way to a small, private dining hall.

Who do you think arrives first? What are you wearing?

The elf dresses in an elegant dark red gown with a plunging neckline and a thigh slit, arriving earliest. Salazar arrives second, almost immediately after Vilde, wearing his *Ring of Silver* robes. He takes in the grandeur of the room and the feast laid out.

Vilde and Salazar, you see that there are two distinct groups making small talk around the dinner table.

In the middle of the room, dominating the conversation with a loud booming laugh, is a bald, gray-bearded man. He is dressed in teal robes, and has glowing tattoos on his face and neck.



Opposite him is a tall, skinny, young man. He has shaggy light blonde hair and piercing blue eyes, accompanied by spectacles and a melancholic smile. They are talking with Vilde's father and mother.

Thaisha is also here already, in conversation with a handsome half-orc dressed in a nice, orange leather jacket. They seem to be whispering to one another, making soft conversation away from the center of the room.

Vilde approaches the Senator, greeting her Mummy with a kiss hello as she helps host the dinner and entertain the guests. Seeing this and knowing about the squabble in the Amadeus family, Salazar heads up to try and help diffuse the tension.

Back in the room, Wukong offers his *Ring of 72 Transformations* to the group for those who wish to bring their armour and weapons to the dinner. Wang Lei and Hazel take him up on the offer. The simian transforms his armour into a suave, white tuxedo as Hazel asks for a black, full-body leather gimp suit with a spiked choker around her neck. Wang Lei opts for his dress uniform, transforming his armour into the standard Victorian Revolutionary Guard's uniform. Raphael joins the trio and asks Wukong to help cast *Disguise Self* on him to hide his physical growths. The sorcerer also pulls his hood up, in case. Raphael also activates his *Cloak of Many Fashions*, shifting it into a black fur coat.

The Party checks their seating, taking their respective seats in accordance to the cards. Hazel, unable to read the cards, hops onto the table at a random seat and begins scarfing down the food. Wang Lei, with his seat stolen by the cleric, takes Hazel's seat instead and surveys the crowd.

WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Wang Lei also recognizes Harondus Eisensturm - the Inspector - as an individual involved in the Victorian Revolutionary Guard, even though he is not in the military in any official capacity. He also spots a *Ring of Candor* on his finger.

Joining the table, you hear the booming laughter of the bald headed man subside.

"And of course, this is Vilde," the Senator introduces the Party. "The rest of them are members of the 52nd Expedition, and have been travelling with my daughter, Vilde, for quite some time in the hunt for the Devourer. Team, this is Brother Aldric Luxjaro and Inspector Harondus Eisensturm.

The skinny, spectacled man known as Inspector Harondus raises an eyebrow as he regards all of you. “Ah, yes, the 52nd Expedition. I understand you had a bit of a run-in with those I am pursuing. More than once, I gather.”

“Yes, yes, dreadful business,” Brother Aldric continues. “We were informed by the scion of House Antarra - Raphael - that Kaelen was responsible not only for the murder of the Castellan, but also my nephew, Benedict.” A dark look crosses the face of the hulking man. “Once I get my hands on him... I assure you that the man will be begging for death.”

“Yes, of course,” The inspector stares at Wang Lei with a steely gaze. “Now, if you don’t mind, I’d like to take all of your statements early tomorrow.”

“Sure, but let’s not talk about work now,” Vilde says. “It’s a dinner. We’re here to have fun.”

“Yes, yes, Harondus,” The Senator agrees. “Business, tomorrow. Tonight is for me to get to know my Expedition. You are here, merely as a guest.”

The inspector raises his hands in mock defeat. “Of course, my lady.”

Hazel continues to scarf down the food, making incredibly rude noises culminating in a satisfying burp. Arianwen notices this and shoots a look at Vilde, raising her eyebrow.

“Uh, do you guys want to ask her to stop?” Arianwen asks. “We’re still waiting on a couple of people.”

“We’re sorry,” Vilde laughs politely. “We just came back from the wild.”

“Can somebody stop her, please?” Senator Arianwen asks.

Wang Lei grapples Hazel, stopping the harregon from continuing to wolf down the food.

Arianwen hangs her head in defeat as the commotion continues. She sighs, looking up and calling out to Halandil.

“Hal,” The Senator calls out. “How long more will the rest of your Party be? Food’s ready, you know.”

Right on cue, Nagano Tokugane and Fiverr both enter the room. Dressed in a stunning white dress with a crazy low-cut, she apologises for her delay. “The rest of our Party is still out foraging, and we had to bring Fiverr over here to the infirmary for a bit.”



Hazel, you see your brother with a bandaged head and leg, which you would recognize is from all your smacking. The harregon hops on to the chair opposite you, smiling and sneering in equal measure. Without further ado, Fiverr begins scarfing down the food as well, making ever louder rude noises.

“Alright, let’s eat!” the Senator declares.

As the feast begins, Arianwen begins trying to learn more about the Party. After taking a huge helping of potatoes, the Senator asks, “Raphael, how has the Lady Isolde been?”

Brother Aldric raises his eyebrows at the hooded man, who responds, “She has been well. We have maintained

correspondence, with her keeping me up to date on matters at home."

"I see, I see," the Senator cuts a slice of venison and eats it completely before continuing, "And, Wang Lei, how's your foster father?"

"I don't know," Wang Lei says. "He hasn't written anything back to me yet. Have you by any chance heard anything?"

The Senator shakes her head sadly, taking a sip from her goblet of Cer'Dorei red wine. "Not particularly, but while we were headed to Leonitar, I heard news that the Guard at Summer's Outpost had to clear out the Sandleford Warren to make way for a train station the dwarves were hoping to build." The Senator continues, "Pardon my ignorance, I am unfamiliar with a paladin's oath. But from my understanding, you are sworn to Prosperity, am I correct?"

"Yes, I am," Wang Lei lies.

CHARISMA (DECEPTION) CHECK

On a successful contested check, Wang Lei fools both Arianwen and Inspector Harondus.

"And, pray tell, what are the tenets of Prosperity?" The Senator asks.

"We are committed to spreading prosperity, of course," Wang Lei explains. "We believe that no one should hoard all the riches."

Brother Aldric lets loose a booming laugh with his mouth full of food. "And what? Give it away to the mean, uneducated oafs who wouldn't know what to do with it?"

"We're here to change this," Wang Lei replies.

Salazar sneers under his breath. "What kind of noble is this, eating with his food spilling out?"

Having heard that, Brother Aldric slaps him on the back and laughs. "What's your name, funny man?"

"Salazar Roko Black," the wizard replies. "Sir."

"And where are you from?"

"Where are you from?" Salazar asks, barely hiding his anger. "You're seating at where I'm supposed to be sitting."

Confused, the Senator shoots a look at Vilde. Vilde shrugs, "Well, I don't know, they're your Expedition now."

"Now, now," Arianwen mediates the outburst, preventing it from escalating into a row. "Brother Aldric

is seated at where he is supposed to be. Now, tell me a little bit more about yourself, Salazar."

"Very well, my lady," Salazar continues. "Honestly, I'm not too sure myself. I thought by going on this Expedition, I'll find out more about my past. There's a part of me that I don't remember."

"And are there any leads?" The Senator asks.

"Yes, there is a lead about liches," Salazar replies. "I'm not related to a lich, but my loss in memory is associated with liches. And actually, my lady, since you are so old and wise -"

"Old?"

"No I mean," The wizard is flustered. "Do you maybe have any knowledge about what the association could be?"

"I mean, I took a look at all of your files beforehand," the Senator continues. "And so I understand you are an accomplished mage with the Ring of Silver, but I see that there is not much known about you before the age of twelve."

"Yes, and I was hoping maybe you know something about this?"

"Right," The Senator narrows her eyes. "What is it do you think I do on a daily basis?"

"I think you govern Nike," Salazar says. "Rule over its people."

"And how would that be related to liches?"

"I was hoping maybe your advisors know a bit more," Salazar continues.

"Right," She continues. "I'm sorry but our primary concern in the Cer'Dorei Republic are giants. They infringe upon elven lands. Do you know anything about giants?"

"Oh, Mummy," Vilde interrupts. "We heard word of frost giants headed to Mezro. We should send a contingent up there."

"Wait, seriously?" The Senator Arianwen looks troubled by this. Turning to her husband, she says, "Angwyn, we should get on this."

Angwyn nods as he continues eating, nonchalantly replying, "Yes, of course, yes, of course."

"Are giants a big concern in Nike?" Salazar asks.

Arianwen shrugs. "I wouldn't say it's a big concern, but it is a concern. Frost giants live on the mountains west of Cer'Dorei, although not many remain." Arianwen explains. "They have been dwindling in their numbers, but we still keep an eye on them."



CHARISMA (DECEPTION) CHECK

On a successful contested check, Hazel goes on a tangent, not only successfully fooling both Arianwen but also Brother Aldric.

Hazel, you take out some mud and start to try and baptize people. As you do so, you only realize at the last second that the hairs on the back of your neck are standing on end. Your tremorsense activates as you sense someone invisible behind you. You feel someone drive a knife deep in between your ribs as blood spurts out onto the table.

Roll initiative!

Appearing out of seemingly nowhere, dropping *Invisibility*, are seven assassins clad in black hoods and face masks. They drive their blades into their victims, turning the feast into a bloody mess.

Poison pours into the cleric's body. Having been invigorated from the scores of food she inhaled, Hazel's body resists the numbing effects of the poison.

Wang Lei, stabbed similarly, feels the poison burn in his veins. As he keels over, his *Belt of Dwarvenkind* hisses with magic, purging the poison from his body. Wang Lei swings his shield in response, dropping the illusion on his *Repulsion Shield* and using it to knock the assassin back.

The assassin stabs viciously into Thaisha's belly, causing the half-orc to scream in pain. Beside her, Wukong dodges one strike only to have the blade slash across his chest twice. Burning poison sears his chest, causing the cursed paladin to hulk out. As the poison takes effect, Wukong feels his throat close up and begins to choke.

Salazar reacts almost instinctively. As the dagger drives into the wizard, a powerful forcefield erupts from Salazar. The *Shield* spell knocks back the assassin, who holds onto his knife by mere fingertips as Salazar casts *Disarming Charm*.

Behind Raphael, the assassin drives his blade twice into the sorcerer. The poison surges into his body as his vision blurs. A numbing sensation spreads from the wound as his throat closes up too.

At the head of the table, Arianwen is skewered twice. The Senator draws her steak knife and engages in melee combat with her assassin as her adrenaline repels the effects of the poison.

Hazel summons her clone, slipping away from the assassin towards the end of the table. The cleric casts *Spirit Guardians*, summoning dozens of spectral i'jins.

"And are they a threat to us?" Vilde asks.

"Not unless they get the *Ring of Winter*," Arianwen jokes. The Party laughs nervously as they remember their previous encounter with Hrothgar.

"And allegedly..." Vilde continues. "What if they do get the *Ring*?"

"Oh, I don't know," Arianwen continues her dinner. "If they do get it, they might be able to start an ice age, freeze the continent or something." Another wave of nervous laughter passes over the group as Arianwen turns to the hungry harregon. "And, ah, Hazel."

The rabbitfolk continues to devour the food, oblivious to the question. Wang Lei nudges the cleric, drawing her attention.

Arianwen continues, "I understand you are a cleric, right? What god are you pledged to?"

Wiping her lips, she says, "Ah, a minor forest god. You wouldn't have heard of her. But, I think many of her tenets are applicable. Our first tenet believes that we all return to nature after we die. It is thus best to get acquainted with nature as much as possible. That's why it is strongly suggested that we get at least three hours of naked contact time with the ground - "

Some of the radiant rabbits sear the assassins, while others begin consuming the food.

Wukong loses control over his lycanthropy. Salazar watches as the raging wereboar charges at the assassin, driving his tusk deep into the creature. The wizard casts *Misty Step*, creating distance between him and the rampaging beast who has once brought Vilde to death's door. Salazar casts *Fire Bolt*, throwing a mote of fire at the assassin that is gored by wereboar.

Wang Lei joins Hazel's clone. He leaps onto the table as he casts *Spirit Guardians*. Spectral soldiers from wars past, glowing deathly green, appears as Wang Lei activates his *Pauldron of the Lost Legion*. The soldiers leap down, slashing at the assassins.

The sorcerer's eyes turns all black as he weaves together a spell with his fingers. Inscribing the sigil of Yog-So'Thoth in the air, a twisting pattern of colors breaks through the Fabric of Reality, mesmerizing the assassins who are knocked in combat.

Halandil grabs Thaisha, pulling the injured druid away from the hypnotized assassin. "Get on the wereboar!" the bard calls out. On that word, Wang Lei feels it reverberate through the base of his skull as supernatural inspiration floods into him.

"Weapons!" Watching Thaisha leave the room, Vilde shouts after the druid. "Get our weapons!"

Following Halandil's lead, Nagano calls out, "Fiverr! On me!" The rabbitfolk rogue leaps onto the samurai as they race towards the exit.

"Breakbones!" Inspector Harondus Eisensturm dashes towards the exit as he calls out for reinforcements. "We're under attack!"

Brother Aldric faces down the wereboar, closing distance with the hulking monster. As he rushes towards the beast, he mutters a quick word of prayer and casts *Bless* on Vilde, Raphael and Wang Lei.

All across the room, the ghastly soldiers and glowing rabbits sear the assassins, incinerating the one gored by Wukong. The divine fire breaks the rest free of their hypnosis, regaining their free will. Hazel seizes the lull in the combat, healing the sorcerer with a powerful *Healing Word* and throwing a mote of fire at another assassin.

"Go, hide!" Vilde shouts. Angwyn scrambles away from the battle unfolding at the dinner table, seeking to hide behind a column on her daughter's call. Drawing her steak and carving knives, Vilde turns the dinnerware into deadly projectiles. They strike true, tearing into the assassin still in combat with Arianwen and drawing his attention. The rogue turns around to try and find his assailant, only for Arianwen to seize the distraction and drive her knife deep into his jugular.

"Are you going to stand there all night, Vilde?" Arianwen laughs as she rushes towards the next assassin.

"What do you mean?" Vilde protests. "I hit him first!"

Wukong surges with supernatural strength, pulverising the massive man to the ground. Brother Aldric is gored by the frenzied lycanthrope. As his magically cursed blood leaks into the beefy Luxjaro man, Brother Aldric contracts lycanthropy. The man thuds his powerful fists into the sides of the wereboar as he tries to break free. As he manages to knock the beast off, Brother Aldric disengages from the fight and charges out the door.

Raising his finger, Salazar casts *Lightning Bolt*. Violent, forking lightning streaks across the room, catching two of the assassins who were too slow to get out of the way.

Wang Lei pummels his mace into the assassin closest to him, caving his skull in like smashing a pumpkin open. The paladin twists, swinging his burning mace into the chest of another assassin.

Watching the rest of his Party and his ex-wife get to safety, Halandil tries to bring Hazel along.

"Stand and fight!" Hazel shouts, grappling the bard and stopping him in his tracks.

Having fled out, Thaisha rushes back to the Expedition's rooms to try and get as much weapons as possible. She successfully finds all of the Expedition's weapons, including *Dawn and Dusk*.

As the poison passes over Raphael, he raises his hands and mutters a quick incantation. Across the room, the assassin behind Wukong sees glowing purple sigils appear on the ground below his feet as tentacles explode out from the sigil, seizing him.

Watching her Mummy cross the threshold towards the assassin under *Hold Person*, Vilde realizes that Thaisha will immediately find *Dawn* and *Dusk*. Wanting to make sure the Senator Arianwen does not realize she has it, the rogue sprints towards the door.

With only four assassins left, of which one is paralyzed, the assassin facing down the towering Wang Lei senses that the fight has tilted completely against their favor. He calls out. "Disappear, now!"

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 20 check, Wang Lei intuits that the assassins are not done with what they came here for. The paladin does not fully believe that they will leave and thinks that it may be a ploy of some sort.

Seeing the last three assassins turn invisible, Hazel shuts her eyes. Directing her clone to fan out, Hazel's clone tries to find the missing assassins as she waits near the main exit. As if guided by divine intervention, the radiant rabbits burn an invisible assassin, allowing Hazel to pinpoint their position.

"There!" The cleric shouts. "There's one behind the assassin under *Hold Person*!" Hazel casts *Produce Flame* and hurls the bolt of fire, searing the invisible attacker. Following suit, Salazar does the same, casting *Fire Bolt* and singeing the same attacker.

Wang Lei does the same. His ghost soldiers fan out and strike another invisible assassin. The spirits grab onto the invisible man, as Wang Lei lets loose a powerful *Eldritch Blast* from his eyes and pulverize the assassin's skull, finally dropping his invisibility.

At the entrance, Thaisha bursts in through the door, slamming into Vilde and knocking her back onto the floor. "Wait wait wait! Stop! Give me the scimitars!"

Nodding quickly, the half-orc passes her weapons to her. Vilde sheathes *Dusk* under her dress as she calls out to Hazel for some mud to disguise the blade.

With no other prey, the frenzying wereboar turns around and sinks its powerful jaws in the neck of the assassin under *Hold Person*. In one forceful bite, Wukong crushes the windpipe of the assassin under the *Hold Person* spell.

The Senator Arianwen closes distance, approaching the assassin revealed by Hazel and Salazar who had been taking cover behind his friend under the *Hold Person* spell. "Who do you work for?!" She demands.

With the battle almost concluded, the group tallies up their kills. Wang Lei, Salazar and Raphael count the bodies and realize just a second too late: there is one more invisible assassin unaccounted for.

Appearing behind the Senator, singed by the Hazel's *Spirit Guardians*, is the last assassin. He leaps across the table as he drives his blade into Arianwen's back, only to withdraw it quickly to drive it in again. The Senator screams in surprise, a sound that is quickly replaced by a wet gurgling as blood begins to pour down her gown.

The assassin in front of her seizes the distraction, slashing her throat open. The Senator collapses on the ground, unconscious.

Vilde screams in horror at the sight. Watching the Senator go down, the Party bursts into action. Wang Lei fires his *Eldritch Blast*; Hazel directs her *Spirit Guardians*; Raphael casts another *Hold Person*. As the resulting deluge of powerful arcana strikes the last two surviving assassins, one is incinerated while the other is paralyzed by tentacles.

Yet it all happens almost a world away for Vilde. The rogue moves before her body even realizes. She arrives at the broken form of the elf that has nurtured her her whole life as hot tears find freedom. Cradling her dying Mummy, Vilde can only watch on as the proud Senator give a soft smile before the light leaves her eyes.